

Prompt 1. The stories about Thor's visits to Utgardaloki (in Gylfaginning) and Geirrod (in Skáldskaparmál) and the tale of Thorstein Mansion-Might (Text 11 on bCourses) draw to some extent on the same narrative materials, yet they differ significantly in their characterization of the protagonist(s). Identify commonalities and differences between these three texts and discuss the possible reasons behind these differences.

Justin Kang

Professor Wellendorf

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A Comparative Study of Thor and Thorstein

The Norse mythological tradition is rich with tales of divine and mortal strength, cosmic journeys, and encounters with giants and magical beings. Among these narratives, Thor's visits to Utgardaloki (in Gylfaginning) and Geirrod (in Skáldskaparmál), and the tale of Thorstein Mansion-Might (Text 11), stand out for their dramatic and heroic elements. Though these stories share several mythic motifs and other similarities, they differ sharply in how they portray their protagonists. While Thor remains the quintessential thunder god whose brute strength is both his glory and downfall, Thorstein emerges as a Christian-era mortal hero who succeeds through courage, cleverness, and moral clarity. These contrasts reflect deeper cultural shifts from paganism to Christianity in medieval Scandinavia and illustrate the evolution of heroic ideals (Clunies Ross, 1994).

All three stories follow a familiar mythological pattern: the hero enters a dangerous or otherworldly realm, encounters formidable opponents, and must rely on strength or cunning strategies to survive. In Gylfaginning, Thor travels with Loki to the realm of Utgardaloki, where he is subjected to humiliating trials that ultimately reveal his limits (Sturluson, 2005). In Skáldskaparmál, Thor finds himself confronting the giant Geirrod, overcoming deadly traps and killing his enemies with Mjólnir. Similarly, in Thorstein Mansion-Might, the character ventures

into the Underworld and Giantland, faces down supernatural beings, and returns home with magical treasures and Christian converts (Pálsson & Edwards, 1985). Each story centers on a hero navigating realms of chaos, highlighting the tension between the mortal and divine, the natural and supernatural (Lindow, 2001).

Yet, Thor and Thorstein differ in profound ways. Thor, in both *Gylfaginning* and *Skáldskaparmál*, is depicted as immensely powerful but not especially wise. In *Gylfaginning*, his feats are ultimately shown to be illusions orchestrated by Utgardaloki. His inability to see through the deception makes him a convoluted figure—strong but gullible. Conversely, in *Skáldskaparmál*, Thor's brute force is second to none: he crushes Geirrod and his daughters with sheer might, reaffirming his role as a divine warrior. These two portrayals reveal a tension within Thor's character: he is both admirable and flawed, divine yet prone to mistakes. In both tales, the line between strength and overconfidence is blurred. While his resilience is celebrated, Thor often lacks foresight, which makes him vulnerable to cunning adversaries (Sturluson, 2005).

Thorstein, by contrast, is a mortal who embodies a different kind of heroism. Though he is introduced as physically imposing and warlike, his real strengths lie in his resolve, cleverness, and adaptability. He uses magical tools, calls on the Christian King Olaf's luck, and navigates dangerous situations not just with force, but with strategy. He willingly accepts Christian teachings and helps spread his faith through diplomacy (Pálsson & Edwards, 1985). While Thor is reactive and elemental, Thorstein is deliberate and moral. He becomes not just a conqueror of giants, but a civilizer and reconciler of two worlds. Additionally, Thorstein's behavior aligns with the narrative purpose of presenting a moral compass for a Christianized audience. His strategic alliances and concern for legacy—particularly through his marriage and governance of

Grundir—indicate a long-term view of heroism, one focused not just on victory but on social and spiritual causes (Clunies Ross, 1994).

The narrative style and themes of Thorstein Mansion-Might further distinguish it from the Thor myths. While Thor's tales are steeped in oral tradition and often laced with humor and exaggeration, Thorstein Mansion-Might follows a more structured saga style, incorporating Christian morality and traditional values. The villain Agdi is demonized as a sorcerer, while King Olaf and Thorstein represent Christian righteousness. Thorstein's success is framed as divine providence rather than fate. The story celebrates not only victory over the otherworldly, but also moral and spiritual triumph. Thorstein's journey thus serves as a Christian allegory where faith, baptism, and loyalty to a Christian monarch are rewarded with both earthly and supernatural success. His rejection of mere material wealth in favor of divine aid further underscores the narrative's ideological differences from Thor myths (Lindow, 2001).

It is also worth noting how the settings of these stories reinforce their thematic goals. Thor's journeys take him into abstract, otherworldly spaces—often magical, deceptive, and symbolic of chaos. These settings lack moral orientation, making Thor's brute strength the only viable response towards conflict in his world. In contrast, Thorstein's world, though also populated by giants and enchanted realms, is mapped more morally. The Christian cross repels evil, magical gifts must be used judiciously, and good actions—such as rescuing a dwarf's son—are met with magical blessings. This moral structure implies a divine order reinforcing Thorstein's universe, mirroring the Christian worldview being established in medieval Scandinavia (Clunies Ross, 1994).

Another key difference lies in how each protagonist relates to community and legacy. Thor's actions are primarily individualistic; he journeys alone or with Loki, and his victories serve the gods more than human society. Thorstein, however, consistently seeks alliances, forms bonds, and ultimately governs a region. His marriage to Gudrun represents the union of old pagan bloodlines with the new Christian order. Moreover, Thorstein's insistence on returning the Whitings to King Olaf and building a new life in Grundir emphasizes a commitment to legacy and societal continuity, themes largely absent in the Thor myths. In this light, Thorstein's saga can be interpreted as a blueprint for the ideal Christian ruler—strong, just, and loyal. (Pálsson & Edwards, 1985).

These shifts in characterization reflect the broader cultural and religious transformation of medieval Scandinavia. As Christianity spread, older pagan stories were reinterpreted to align with new values. Thorstein's saga blends the fantastic elements of Norse myth with Christian ideology, producing a hybrid hero suitable for a Christian audience. The contrast between Thor's unyielding, sometimes brute violence and Thorstein's clever pragmatism reveals how the image of the ideal hero evolved with changing beliefs. Mythic structure remained, but the meaning it conveyed was transformed (Lindow, 2001).

In conclusion, the stories of Thor and Thorstein illustrate the dynamic nature of myth and heroism in Norse literature. While Thor embodies the raw, chaotic power of the pagan gods, Thorstein represents the moral order and faith-driven courage of the Christian age. Both are heroic in their own right, but their differences show how mythology adapts to cultural change. Through these narratives, we see not just battles with giants and feats of strength, but a civilization negotiating its identity between the worlds of gods and men, of the old ways and the

new. As medieval Scandinavia transitioned from a polytheistic society to a Christian one, so too did its stories—and its heroes (Clunies Ross, 1994).

Works Cited

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